

Parallelism and Parallel Construction

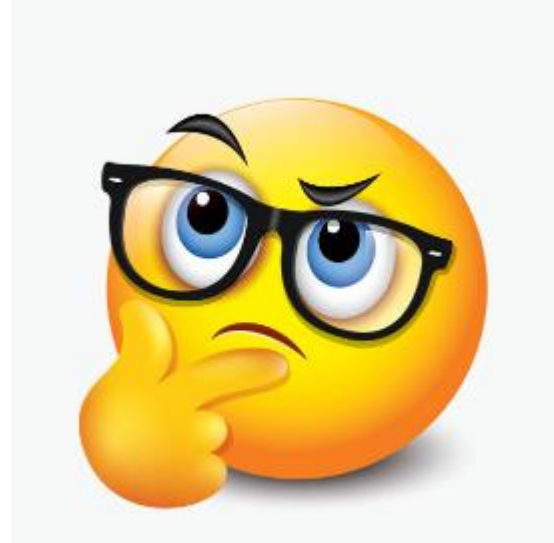
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Parallelism (also known as parallel structure) is the requirement that coordinate parts of a sentence be identical in grammatical form.

E.g., If you begin a list with an -ing word (gerund), every subsequent item in that list must also be a gerund.

Is it right?

The candidate is energetic, ambitious, and has a lot of intelligence.



I. Parallelism in Core Grammatical Units

A. Lists and Series

Items in a series must be of the same grammatical category (all nouns, all adjectives, all verbs, etc.).

Incorrect: The candidate is **energetic**, **ambitious**, and has a lot of intelligence.

"Energetic" and "ambitious" are adjectives, but "has a lot of intelligence" is a verb phrase.

Correct: The candidate is **energetic**, **ambitious**, and intelligent. (All adjectives)

I. Parallelism in Core Grammatical Units

B. Gerunds and Infinitives

Mixing gerunds (-ing) and infinitives (to + verb) is a classic trap.

Incorrect: He likes swimming, hiking, and to ride a bicycle.

Why: "Swimming" and "hiking" are gerunds; "to ride" is an infinitive.

Correct: He likes swimming, hiking, and cycling.

Correct: To swim, to hike, and to cycle are his favorite hobbies. (Maintain the infinitive throughout).

I. Parallelism in Core Grammatical Units

C. Verb Tense and Form

While tenses can change to reflect time, the structure of the verb should remain parallel when describing a sequence of actions.

Incorrect: The manager opened the file, checked the data, and the report was signed.

Why: The first two verbs are Active Voice; the third shifts to Passive Voice.

Correct: The manager opened the file, checked the data, and signed the report.

II. Correlative Conjunctions: The "Balance" Rule

Correlative conjunctions work in pairs. The most vital rule for exams is that the grammatical element following the first part must match the grammatical element following the second part.

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1. Not only... but also

If "not only" precedes a verb, "but also" must precede a verb.

Incorrect: He was not only accused of theft but also of murder.

Why: "Not only" is followed by a verb (accused), but "but also" is followed by a prepositional phrase (of murder).

Correct: He was **accused** not only **of theft** but also **of murder**.
(Both follow "of")

Alternative Correct: He was **not only accused** of theft **but also suspected** of murder. (Both follow verbs)

II. Correlative Conjunctions: The "Balance" Rule

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2. Either...or...

Requires identical structures on both sides.

II. Correlative Conjunctions: The "Balance" Rule

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3. Neither...nor...

Requires identical structures on both sides.

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4. Both...and....

Requires identical structures on both sides.

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5. Whether...or...

(Usually used for choices between two clauses or phrases.)

Requires identical structures on both sides.

II. Correlative Conjunctions: The "Balance" Rule

Correlative conjunctions work in pairs. The most vital rule for exams is that the grammatical element following the first part must match the grammatical element following the second part.

6. Rather...than...

Used to express preference between two parallel actions.

Requires identical structures on both sides.

III. Parallelism in Comparisons

When comparing two things using than or as, the items compared must be functionally and grammatically equal.

Incorrect: The syllabus of SSC is more vast than RRB.

Why: This compares the "syllabus" (a thing) to "RRB" (an exam/organisation).

You must compare syllabus to syllabus.

Correct: The syllabus of SSC is more vast than that of RRB.

Correct: The syllabus of SSC is more vast than the syllabus of RRB.

N. B.

Compare like with like (use "that of" for singular, "those of" for plural)

IV. Subject-Verb Agreement with Correlatives

In competitive exams, parallelism often intersects with Subject-Verb Agreement.

The Proximity Rule:

When subjects are joined by either...or, neither...nor, or not only...but also, the verb must **agree with the subject closest to it**.

Incorrect: Neither the principal nor the teachers is present.

Correct: Neither the principal nor the teachers are present.
(Teachers is plural and closer to the verb).

V. 'Traps' and Exceptions

The "Preposition" Trap

If a preposition applies to all items in a list, you must either:

1. Place the preposition once before the entire list.
2. Repeat the preposition before every item.

Incorrect: He is interested **in** art, music, and **in** literature.

Correct: He is interested **in** art, music, and literature.

Correct: He is interested **in** art, **in** music, and **in** literature.

V. 'Traps' and Exceptions

No Sooner... Than

It requires an inverted auxiliary verb and a parallel clause structure.

Incorrect: No sooner ~~he had~~ reached the station than the train left.

Correct: No sooner **had he** reached the station **than** the train left.

Error Note:

Exams often replace "than" with "when" or "then."

Always use **than**.

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VI. 'Traps' and Exceptions

Watch for these "hidden" imbalances:

The "Adverb vs. Adjective" Trap:

Error: The car is fast, reliable, and drives smoothly.

Fix: The car is fast, reliable, and smooth. (Parallel adjectives).

VI. 'Traps' and Exceptions

Watch for these "hidden" imbalances:

The "Hidden Clause" Trap:

Error: I believe that he is honest and he will succeed.

Fix: I believe that he is honest and that he will succeed. (The "that" must be repeated for clarity in formal exams).

VI. 'Traps' and Exceptions

Watch for these "hidden" imbalances:

The "Split" Correlative:

Error: Not only did he lose his ticket, but his luggage as well.

Fix: He lost not only his ticket but also his luggage.